economies. By comparing where India is today, with where those countries were at similar stages in their development, as well as by looking at what they did next, we might get a better perspective on what India might need to do. Of course, any such analysis has to be accompanied by two important caveats –

i. First, countries differ and do not necessarily follow similar trajectories;
ii. Second, the global environment has changed.

The opportunities India faces now are different from those that previous fast growers faced when they were at a similar stage of development. Thus, blindly replicating their trajectory may be unwise.[4]

COMPARING GROWTH AND TRADE

If we analyse the various economic outcomes for selected Asian countries around their dates of initial 'takeoff' into periods of high growth, we identify the year of takeoff for comparator Asian countries based on IMF (2006)[5] the dates are 1979, 1973, and 1967 for China, Indonesia, and Korea respectively. For India, taking the year of takeoff as 1991, when major economic reforms began, the following narrative is clear as given below :

- India was growing at similar rates as other Asian economies before takeoff. After takeoff, it kept pace with Indonesia, but China and Korea grew faster.
- Setting date 0 as the year the country's per capita GDP in 2000 US dollars, crossed $500;
- By the time India's dependency ratio falls below 40 per cent, China's growth is more robust under both these alternatives, while India's matches that of Indonesia.
- Korea's trajectory is similar to India's in the initial years after takeoff, though after 10 years the slope of its trajectory increases steeply.
- By plotting an index of a country's share of world trade, with year 0 based on our first takeoff definition (1979, 1973, 1967, and 1991 for